

Kenyon:

I just finished reading your chapters 1 and 2 and you raise the problems you see with Fordism very clearly (pp. 13-19). It does require some reorganization especially since some points (see assembly line pp. 6 and 44; turnover of workers, pp. 20 and 43; Stanley and Smith, pp. 25-28 and 77-79) are repeated in both chapters.

First, you have theoretical parts spread across both chapters, at least in a way that does not seem organized to me. Perhaps you could introduce some of the conditions at the River Rouge plant in the first chapter and then use it as a springboard for your overall theoretical perspective and then in chapter 2 have a more detailed account of Fordism in practice (and of GM's Modern Housing Corporation) and your critique of it. This is just a suggestion—and there may be other, better ways—but as it currently stands it doesn't quite work.

Second, going back to my comments on your Brazil chapter, you need to clarify the nature of wage labor in capitalism clearly (pp. 49-53); This may be a place actually to bring in your discussion of part lifetime proletarians, etc that you currently have in the Brazil chapter.

On "primitive accumulation" you may want to look at Teodor Shanin's Late Marx and the Capitalist Road. He may have an article summary of it in Journal of Peasant Studies, Review (mid-1980s) or some other place. Basically, his argument is that in the last 10 years of his life Marx published very little but filled notebooks because he was rethinking the origins of capitalism and that he wanted to model vol. 3 of Capital on Russia just as he had modeled vol. 1 on England...but don't worry too much on this except to note that most work on primitive accumulation take units of jurisdiction as units of analysis...if you move away from that as Quijano and Wallerstein do, then it looks different

In your critique, perhaps you could more forcefully use world-system's commodity chain concept and the axial division of labor; to say that units of analysis should be girded by the commodity chains which includes raw materials (rubber, etc), labor (both to produce the rubber, copper, steel, etc. and to assemble cars) and the food for the laborers.

Intensive vs Extensive regimes of accumulation (p. 10): you don't examine these terms. Perhaps you should. Usually, extensive regimes mean extending the scale, and intensive deepening (using more technology, widening the market).

On the Modern Housing corporation (pp. 84-86 esp) was this a part of a larger movement from the Pullman towns in Illinois...remember Fred Johnson of Endicott-Johnson building houses (in Floral Ave in JC and elsewhere) and selling them at cost to workers (also a good way to dampen worker radicalism as Mel Dubovsky noted (see 45-48 minute mark): (<https://www.pbs.org/video/wskg-public-telecommunications-johnson/>). So can it be said that just as Ford did not invent the assembly line as you argue, GM did not invent company housing for workers? On this point, can we also draw parallels with housing for indentured labor? Also that in many cases (not sure this applied to Malaysia), indentured workers had to buy groceries and other necessities of life at the plantation store at high prices (I think I have read about this in Jan Bremen's work on Fiji but not sure).

While I see why you refer to Ford and GM in the opening chapter, I think it would be good to make the theoretical points there and then go to the concrete example...perhaps the critique of Fordism and the Regulation School can come there. In this connection, Mike Davis wrote a long review essay on the Regulation School in Fernand Braudel Center's Review (1978) that might be useful. See also Gambino's critique that echoes some of the points you make (I've attached it to this email as well); Carl Dassbach whom you cite is a Binghamton sociology graduate (we graduated at the

same time) and his dissertation should be available in the department (I believe its 2 volumes) and certainly in the library; he also wrote an article in Review of International Political Economy that may be of some use. See also the chapter by Arrighi and Silver attached to this email on the workplace and market bargaining power of labor that may also be of use to you. Joan Scott wrote a book, Gender and the Politics of History that may have some chapters of interest

Minor points:

■ pp. 3-4: Chandler's 'visible hand' was not the market but managerial direction; this was enabling corporate managers to plan production rather than depend on the vagaries of the market (see p. 11)

■ p. 39, fn. 99: be careful dealing with Tirthankar Roy; he is usually an apologist for the Brits though I have not read the article you cite here

■ p. 46: 'hegemon,' 'Eerie'—these typos from the earlier draft are reproduced here!

■ p. 49: forces and relations of production are in Marx...don't cite Althusser for this

■ p. 62: In Fraser's tracking of the 'shifting configuration of social reproduction,' what about the 'belle epoch' at the turn of the 20th century when again there was a financialization of capital (all the literature on Finance Capital and 'Imperialism as the highest (or last) stage of capitalism')

■ pp. 81-82: on housing and residential segregation...were there 'sun-down towns' in Michigan?

Footnote numberings should start anew each chapter.

On citations in footnotes: Usually if you are citing the same work sequentially, use "ibid., p." If there are intervening citations, you could use "Wallerstein, op. cit., p."

It would be good to have a really strong first sentence/para on the first page of your first chapter (at the final revision...remember this is the first piece of your writing that the external examiner will read).

I am leaving for New Orleans on Wednesday 6/3 and for India on Saturday; if you want to talk we can set up a time. While chatting in India is a possibility, the nine hour 30 minute time difference could make it a pain.

Chapter 1

Ravi:

This is a substantial improvement over the previous version I had seen, especially your attempts to link Fordism in the US with components of the automobile commodity chain in the semiperiphery (Brazil) and periphery (colonial Malaya) and to link it to housing which is a nice way to connect it to feminist critiques of the labor process literature.

Your discussion of housing is a particularly sharp way to link the work of women and the reproduction of labor to factory life and to show how gender is constitutive of class relations.

You have used Joan Smith and Kathleen Stanley's work well linking it both to white ethnics and to Black workers.

I am glad you look at Aglietta. He is central to discussions about Fordism in the US. It may be useful to look also at the work of Alain Lipietz as he tries to link Fordism to work in the periphery through concepts like 'bloody Taylorism.' Amin's disarticulation of peripheral economies is important but of course the Gunder Frank's work (and I suspect the work of Raúl Prebisch and others in ECLA) predated him.

I would like to have seen a deeper discussion of the commodity chain and the rise of the vertically integrated corporation of which the River Rouge plant was the epitome. I refer both to Chandler's Visible Hand and to Arrighi's argument about US hegemony being, in the sphere

of production, the internalization of transaction costs. Here I would also perhaps include Bunker and Ciccantelli's argument that structural changes in world accumulation required multiple technological, organizational, social, and political innovations as the scale of production increased since raw materials were not evenly distributed across the world. The discussion on Fordlandia is very interesting but I wonder if the focus on "Cape Cod-styled shingled houses" (p. 23) takes away from the fact that rubber production was very different from the making of automobiles. In other words, it was not only its semiperipheral location in Brazil that was problematic but the production of rubber could not create the type of stratified labor created by Fordism in Michigan. You indeed hint at this when you talk about differences in rubber production in Congo and in colonial Malaya.

Minor points

■ Pp. 2-3: Not that a few factories in Michigan came "to dominate the world of production" but of automobile production. Perhaps it would be good to make an argument that automobile production was the leading sector/quintessential sector of production in the twentieth century à la Beverly Silver in her *Forces of Labor*.

■ P. 25: "development of underdevelopment" may have been used by Amin but it was first coined by Gunder Frank.

■ Perhaps look at the Great Migration in the context of the growth of Detroit?

Overall, I think this is almost ready to be defended. I think all that has to be done is a more general discussion (not more than 2-4 paragraphs) on commodity chains and related labor policies that link Fordism in the core to working conditions in the periphery. And perhaps a slightly more nuanced discussion about gender and household composition in the periphery and semiperiphery to go with the discussion in the core. In the case of Malaysia, unlike the case of the Congo, as you note migrant (indentured) labor from South India were recruited rather than indigenous Malays. This also opens up the possibility of how their food was supplied and then you have the case of production zones, zones of labor recruitment, and zones of provisioning the labor. This needs only to be discussed at a general theoretical level rather than in any substantial detail. Look at Daniel Headrick's books (I think it's called *Tenacles of Progress* but this is vague) for Malaya and also perhaps Jan Breman on indentured labor in Malaya. Much of this is a more general comment and this is defensible with very minor changes. Let's talk when you have the chance. I can do Friday the 5th or anytime after the 8th of Jan. And when we talk, we also need to think about publishing a version of this, say in the *International Labour and Working Class History*, *Critical Sociology*, or *Journal of World-Systems Research* (my preference would be *ILWCH*...see their latest issue <https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/international-labor-and-working-class-history/latest-issue>

Excellent work. I attach a lightly marked up version of your paper.

Chapter 2

Walden:

I think this is a fine paper, one that is eminently publishable. I would, however, have a couple of comments, which the author may want to ponder in finalizing it.

First, it would be worthwhile to engage the latest work by Marxist feminists from the global South like Naferti Tadiar. In Tadiar's recently published *Remaindered Lives*, she distinguishes between those who lead what she calls "productive lives" in the sense of directly contributing to the creation of surplus value and workers with "disposable or surplus lives" who are

marginalized from the process of directly creating value but play a central role in the the social reproduction of capital beyond the household in that they service the people that are engaged in the direct production of value or in its extraction, and these include the families of those living productive lives. But while the former live productive lives in the sense of yielding value and expanding it, the latter live lives that are sucked of value, that is, the value of their lives ‘declines irreversibly over time.’ If the expenditure of labor time is the process by which value is extracted and accumulated in the traditional work context, it is through the expenditure of ‘life-times’ that value is drawn from surplus lives that are occasionally and temporarily ‘redeemed’ from their status of disposable lives to support the reproduction of lives-worth-living before they are thrown back to it.

Tadiar, as noted above, goes beyond the family setting to focus on entire strata of workers, such as domestics and other providers of household work, migrant workers relegated to ‘dirty jobs,’ those in precarious occupations, migrant contract workers, and those deemed as having no value at all except when they are occasionally and temporarily called to service those who live lives worth living fall into this teeming mass of disposable lives. Their lives are marked by the ‘struggle to be human,’ to join those whose lives are worth living, but are barred by states that determine the conditions of ‘full citizenship’ in a capitalist democracy and serve as border guards against those pressing to get in.

In Tadiar’s view, the dispossession of communities in the global South and their relegation to producing the surplus lives that are forced to migrate to serve as the source of reproductive work for those directly engaged in productive work has become the main axis of domination and exploitation in the extraction and accumulation of value in today’s financialized global capitalism, in contrast to traditional Marxist analysis, where the focus was and continues to be on how capital extracts value from labor in the process of production in the dominant capitalist economies.

I am attaching a review I made of Tadiar’s work

2. On the family under capitalism, I’d like to say first of all that we must situate it in a historical process in which the subjugation of earlier modes of production entailed had dissolving and conserving effects on institutions like the family. The debate detailed in the paper on the relationship to capitalism to the family appears to be between views that commonly assume that the family under capitalism emerged ex nihilo and was not affected or “overdetermined” by earlier pre-capitalist (petty bourgeois in the case of rural America) family structures.

3. Related to this, I think the debate also seems to be between those that (in the finest tradition of instrumentalism) see the family as a tool of capitalism and those that see it, in the manner of E.P Thompson, as a source of resistance. On the contrary, my sense is that the family is a “conflictive unity,” which capitalism seeks to subjugate but which also provides protection from Capital and also engenders resistance. In this sense, the family is a pressure cooker that is imperfectly subjugated by capital to produce docile workers. I am not that familiar with the massive strikes of the thirties, but I would think that a key source of resistance that sustained the workers through months of resistance was the family.

4. This leads to my last comment, which is that it strikes me that in the narration of Ford’s “Five Dollar Day” and GM’s effort to “Americanize” the work force with its residential program in Flint, workers come across as a pliable, unresisting mass. I think to complete the picture, one must also show how workers resisted management’s effort to manage not only their life in the factory but also their life at home.

In sum, Capital seeks to exercise hegemony in all dimensions of social life, but its efforts always fall short of subjugating communities, which often resort to different forms

of resistance, including the so-called weapons of the weak. Rule always involve some degree of compromise between the rulers and the ruled.

Ravi:

This is a much, much improved version though some of the issues from last May's version remain but that is fine for now.

After this, when revising it for publication it would be useful to reframe its architecture—for instance, when you refer to Marx's notion of "socially necessary labor time" (p. 8) as Wallerstein, Arrighi, and Hopkins show in the first chapter of their *Antisystemic Movements* book, he retreats into the very national political economy that he had earlier transcended...and if you could link your mention (but not discussion) of Malaysia, Africa, and Latin America (p. 39) with the reference to migration (p. 10—see discussion on incorporation in *Review* 1987, issue 5/6 (the intro article by Wallerstein and Hopkins)...it could be a very powerful article breaking new ground...and the basis for your dissertation. Perhaps link state welfare policies here to what Polanyi says about the 'self-protection' of society available to workers in the core but not to the colonies (*Great Transformation*, p. 192).

Again, on women and capitalism/reproduction, you need to look at the relevant chapters of Joan Scott's *Gender and the Politics of History*.

But these are simply points to make it stronger for publication...this is excellent as a second year paper

Ravi

Hi Kenyon:

It was good talking with you last week and I finally got to read your chapter on Brazil. It is a good attempt and reads well but needs a bit more detail, especially on the Ford plantations.

My main reservation is that in your discussion on Fordlandia, there is very little about labor, much more about housing, consumption, etc.

One issue that you may want to clarify (and I think we have talked about it in relation to one of your earlier chapters. You refer to Wallerstein's part lifetime proletarians in p. 4 but this somehow disappears in the section on "Free laborer" (pp. 12ff). Were Indigenous people really "cut off from the land" (p. 13)? Did entire families lose access or just the male workers? Also were women employed in wild rubber harvesting? See also Banaji's chapter on "Modes of Production in a Materialist Conception of History" (first published in an early issue of *Capital and Class*). This comes up again at the end of the section when you say that the rubber tappers "were not, strictly speaking, wage workers" (p. 33). OK. But so what? They were working within capitalism—or the capitalist mode of production, no?

That chapter will also be of use to you in discussing Barbara Weinstein's work (pp. 25-29) as he make a distinction between 'mode of production' and 'forms of labor exploitation' which he actually goes back on in part in his chapter on "Gunder Frank in Retreat" (I say this from memory as it is a long time since I read that piece). In Weinstein's case at least the opposition of "production for the world market" to "mode of production" is not only to reduce 'mode of production' to a form of labor exploitation but also to take jurisdictional entities as units of analysis.

I wonder if this discussion, especially of how to characterize labor, can be made largely in your introductory chapter and then merely reference it in this and other substantive chapters because it takes so much space here (pp. 4-5, 12ff, 28-30). Also, if the rubber boom started in the 1870s (p. 6), while the discussion of the "Indigenous peoples" (pp.

13-19) provides an important context, much of this is a prelude to the rubber boom and so perhaps can be shortened, so too the section on the 'grand seca.'

This would allow you the space to develop the sections on rubber. Especially since you say that recent scholarship has "shifted towards micro-level and local considerations" (p. 25), are there any figures on the numbers of rubber tappers? Were there any gang bosses or were these independent operators? On wages?

I like your discussion of the debt relation (p. 31). Is there any reference to who the creditors were? Did they just enjoy conspicuous consumption or did they invest their ill gotten gains productively? Was there any attempt by any of them to process the rubber?

Were there any figures of production on Ford's estates? Any indication of the organization of production?

Minor points:

■ Global North and Global South: just wondering why you don't use 'core' and 'periphery' or high-income and low-income; also how will you classify Brazil within a zonal divisioning of labor at this time? Note by the late 19th century, Argentina had one of the highest per capita incomes: see David Denoon, *Settler Capitalism: The Dynamics of Dependent Development in the Southern Hemisphere*, Oxford 1983.

■ p. 4: what about other sources of food from other areas (from other parts of Latin and Central America, elsewhere?)

■ p. 5: rubber used for "syringes"? Really? This is a question...I did not know

■ p. 6: what is a 'long tonne'?

■ pp. 7-8: I like your use of Bunker's difference between productive and extractive economies for rubber but perhaps 'extractive' is not the best word for this as it does also make one think of extracting resources like petroleum....

■ p. 9: from which other countries were laborers recruited and did their conditions of employment differ?

■ p. 13: capitalize the first letter of 'Indigenous people' but not 'people indigenous to the region'

■ p. 19: Was Brazil the last country to abolish slavery in the Americas or in the world? Again a question since I don't know the answer

■ p. 30: surplus retained by tappers who buy land in the city—this needs to be developed

On a side note, the last time I was in Brazil about 8 years ago, a friend's daughter was interviewing for an academic job in Manaus! My friend—Antonio Brussi—is a Binghamton sociology Ph.D. and I heard then about the opulence of the town and saw photos of its famed opera house before rubber from Malaya screwed everything up!

Finally, I attach an article from today's NY Times. I found it interesting that the Brits did not baptize their slaves because they didn't believe Christians could be enslaved but the Catholics baptized them because then they got eternal salvation!!!

Chapter 4:

Happy New Year, Kenyon

I have finally been able to read your chapter on Peru and learnt so much from it. I simply had no idea of the Putomayo genocide and the operations of the rubber industry there....as the many exclamation marks show! I like in particular your descriptions and analyses of racism.

In general, as it stands it is much too descriptive and needs to be more analytical. Taussig is helpful, certainly but I think looking at the issue globally, other aspects need to be brought in.

This could be done in several ways. For instance, at about the same time as the atrocities were being committed against the indigenous populations by the Peruvian Amazon Company, the Belgians in the Congo were also brutalizing Africans in the rubber industry (see King Leopold's Ghost). Can this be theorized?

Bringing in people from Barbados—as enforcers especially—that is to say people from a jurisdiction controlled by another power is an interesting twist. Also note though (and of course the brutality was largely absent), sugarcane planters in Hawai'i brought Portuguese to be labor supervisors to the plantations there. There is a literature on colonial overlords bringing subordinate peoples from another area to be a layer between them and the colonized (Indians in East Africa). Did the strategic importance and/or natural characteristics of the crops, social structures in the peripheries/edges of empires have anything to do with the different patterns of labor control?

Another aspect that needs to be discussed theoretically is the issue of “production and consumption [being] mediated through exchange” (pp. 27-34). One argument Wallerstein and others make is that capitalism will come to an end if the capitalists have to provide fully for the reproduction of the labor force; that much of the reproduction costs are borne by the households (small family plots, informal labor, extended families rearing children, etc) and therefore most people are part-lifetime proletarians. This of course does not apply to the situation here because they are working them to death—not even providing food the the long marches. But that does not apply to the Barbadians to the same extent. How does all this fit with say, the Congo?

On another matter: there needs to be some discussion about the nature of the Peruvian Amazon Company—its structure, what say, was its relations legally and otherwise with “Columbian rubber agents” (p. 18).

Minor points:

■ Pp. 1-2: labor system not as ‘pre-capitalist’ or ‘non-capitalist’....see Jairus Banaji’s “Modes of Production in a Materialist Conception of History” in Capital & Class (I think 1977) and reprinted in his Theory as History

■ P. 13: “colonial hegemony”—perhaps rephrase

■ It would be helpful to the reader, perhaps even as a footnote, to say something about the border between Peru and Colombia and the treaty/agreement of 1927.

■ P. 35: meatpacking in Chicago...perhaps not for this chapter, but see Devil in the White City.

I attach a lightly marked up version of your text

Let's talk when you have the time and hope you had a good break.

Best

Ravi

Chapter 5:

Kenyon:

A very good first draft.

One issue is that the focus on Malaya takes away the focus on other areas of rubber production—in Africa and in other Asian countries. Why were indentured labor in Malaya cheaper than labor (including presumably indentured labor) elsewhere? Were

growing conditions in Malaya better than elsewhere?

Why were Tamils the preferred group of indentured labor to Malaya? Bengal was closer for instance. Note that Headrick, Breman and others say that indentured labor was preferred in Malaya, parts of Ceylon, Fiji both to better control the laborers because they had no social support and because the colonial rulers did not want to disturb indigenous social structures in these regions (see p. 8).

When you use caste (kshatriya, p. 28) note the four-fold varna system did not apply to the Tamil country.

B. R. Tomlinson's work argues that between the two world wars, the British colonial government in India gained a considerable degree of autonomy from the government in London because they argued that they needed more autonomy to deal with the nationalist movement.

Interesting that you use Dipesh Chakravarty. I think his theoretical points—the ones you invoke re: sardar—are on point even if his empirical chapters are dubious. You may want to look also at Leela Fernandes' work on labor (though it is of a later period). See too Jairus Banaji's discussion of modes of production in (I think) *Capital & Class* 1977 (it may be a chapter in one of his books too) of how capitalism uses different labor processes

On the Chinese in the Malay tin mines, see the work of Daniel Headrick, *Tentacles of Progress*.

Minor points:

■ Kangany or Kangani?

■ p 2. Malaysia usually seen as part of Southeast Asia rather than South Asia

■ p. 2: Any evidence that Malaysia was sparsely populated? On prime facie grounds one would assume it was more densely populated than the Amazon basin

■ p. 2: “experienced class of planters”—where/how did they gain “experience”

■ p. 2: Tamils working in rubber plantations in Malaya from 1840 when on p. 3 you say that rubber seeds were taken to Kew Gardens in 1870s?

■ p. 5: more a question..was Malaya separated from British India in 1867 or 1857 (when the British Crown took over the government of India from the East India Company)?

■ p. 6: European or British capital?

■ p. 7: Indonesia—this was a Dutch colony. Singapore...did it have land for plantations; on p. 13...since Java was part of the Dutch East Indies how were Javanese labor brought on indentured contracts/

■ pp. 12 ff: Gandhi not Ghandi

Good work

Ravi